

[Report 019] Cohere - Technical Program Manager, AI Delivery for Public Sector & Defence

Score: 2.6/5

URL: <https://jobs.ashbyhq.com/cohere/f8e85a7c-1eb0-47f8-8140-1c4e7892f17d>

PDF: 

Legitimacy: High Confidence

Verification: confirmed (WebFetch)

Date: 2026-05-21

A) ROLE SUMMARY

Dimension	Detail
Archetype	Technical AI PM + AI Forward Deployed (hybrid)
Domain	AI/LLM / Government & Defence
Function	Manage / Deploy / Advise
Seniority	Senior (7+ years EPM/TPM)
Remote	Flexible - Germany-based (offices Toronto, NYC, SF, London, Paris)
Team size	Not stated
TL;DR	Customer-facing TPM managing end-to-end AI delivery for German government and defence clients - requires security clearance eligibility, deep LLM technical knowledge, and government procurement expertise.

B) MATCH WITH CV

JD Requirement	CV Match	Strength
7+ years as Engineering / Technical Program Manager	15+ years program and project management across Windesheim, Aeres, Tonomy, COTIT, Social Chicken; Prince2, ITIL certified	Strong on years; context gap (education/labs vs. enterprise/government)
2+ years customer-facing technical delivery (enterprise or AI/ML)	Investor and partner-facing delivery at Viridis, Tonomy, Open Food Chain; KONGSBERG BI deployments (BP, Statoil) - actual enterprise field delivery	Partial - strongest signal is KONGSBERG (2012) which is dated
Experience with government, defence, or heavily regulated customers	KONGSBERG work for BP, Statoil in Norway; ESIEA digital forensics research (geopolitical risk); no German government or defence background	Weak
LLM training, fine-tuning, or deployment experience	Self-hosted OpenWebUI, Flowise, n8n; AI sandbox deployment; AI stack for student research	Partial - operations/deployment, not fine-tuning or production LLM
German government security clearance eligibility	EU citizen (NL), based in Baarn; no current or prior German security clearance; would need to obtain (12-18 months noted in JD)	Weak/Blocker
German/English bilingual	English near-native, German conversational	Partial - conversational German may not meet requirements for government client work

Understanding of deployment architectures (cloud, on-prem, hybrid, air-gapped)	Docker, Kubernetes, Linux, private cloud, NAS, CI/CD; self-hosted stack on own infrastructure	Strong on self-hosted/hybrid; limited air-gapped enterprise experience
Navigating procurement processes and contractual obligations	Grant writing, contracts at Tonomy Foundation, COTIT commercial restructuring; no government procurement experience	Weak
Data sovereignty, privacy compliance, algorithmic impact assessments	CSRD/CSDDD/EUDR compliance work (VCH); blockchain for traceability and privacy	Partial - supply chain compliance, not public sector data governance
PMP / PgMP certification	Prince2, ITIL, Scrum - not PMP/PgMP	Partial

Gaps:

- German government security clearance** - This is a hard blocker. The JD explicitly states "eligible for German government security clearance (Top Secret preferred)" and notes the process takes 12-18 months. As a Dutch EU citizen with no prior German defence/government relationship, obtaining this clearance is uncertain and slow.
- German language depth** - Government client-facing work in Germany typically requires business-level German at minimum. "Conversational" German is likely insufficient for CIO/IT director relationship management in German government.
- Defence / public sector domain knowledge** - Zero background in German public sector, Bundeswehr, or national security contexts. KONGSBERG work was oil & gas (BP/Statoil), not defence.
- LLM fine-tuning / production ML** - The role asks for comfort with "LLM training, fine-tuning, or deployment." Self-hosting OpenWebUI and Flowise is ops/deployment, not model training or fine-tuning. Gap at the technical depth expected for a Cohere customer-facing TPM.
- Government procurement** - EU grant writing is adjacent but German government procurement (framework agreements, tendering, security review cycles) is a specific domain with steep learning curve.

The hard blocker: Security clearance eligibility is the single most disqualifying factor. Without it, the role cannot proceed. The JD makes clearance a primary requirement, not a nice-to-have.

C) LEVEL AND STRATEGY

Level detected: Senior TPM with 7+ years, customer-facing, defence-adjacent. This is a senior role with specific domain requirements that are hard to proxy.

Christiaan's natural level for this archetype: The TPM / program management competency is strong. But the domain (German government, defence, security clearance) creates hard constraints that cannot be addressed through framing.

Recommendation: Do not pursue. The clearance requirement alone makes this non-viable for a Dutch citizen based in the Netherlands targeting a German government role with no prior clearance or German government relationship. This is a structural barrier, not a skills gap.

D) COMP AND DEMAND

Metric	Data
Senior TPM at AI company, Germany	€90,000-€140,000
Cohere compensation	Competitive for a Series C+ AI company; 6 weeks vacation, full health, 100% parental leave top-up confirmed
Christiaan's target	€65,000-€90,000
Comp alignment	Above target - but role conflicts on clearance
Demand trend	Government AI delivery roles are in demand but clearance requirements dramatically reduce candidate pool

Sources: Glassdoor Cohere reviews, LinkedIn senior TPM Germany benchmarks, JD benefits section.

E) CUSTOMIZATION PLAN

Not recommended. The security clearance hard blocker makes this role non-viable regardless of customization quality.

#	Section	Assessment
1	Overall	Hard blocker (clearance) makes this non-applicable
2	Cohere as company	Interesting AI company; watch for EMEA Solutions, AI Implementation, or Innovation roles without clearance requirements
3	Alternative at Cohere	Any customer-facing AI delivery or solutions role in EMEA that does not require government clearance would be a better fit

F) INTERVIEW PLAN

Not applicable - recommendation is not to apply.

G) POSTING LEGITIMACY

Assessment: High Confidence

Signal	Finding	Weight
Posting freshness	Ashby platform, active listing; Cohere is actively hiring	Positive
Apply button	Active via Ashby	Positive
JD specificity	Highly specific - names exact clearance levels (Top Secret), specific tools (GC Cloud, Protected B/C), exact German regulatory context	Positive
Requirements realism	7+ years TPM, specific clearance - realistic for this niche role	Positive
Cohere hiring signals	Well-funded AI company (Series C+), active European expansion, Germany office	Positive
Reposting detection	Not found in scan-history	Neutral
Role market context	Niche defence/government AI role; small candidate pool; legitimately takes months to fill	Positive

Context Notes: This is a credible, active, highly specific posting. The challenge is fit, not legitimacy.

KEYWORDS EXTRACTED

Technical Program Manager, AI delivery, public sector, defence, government, security clearance, LLM deployment, data sovereignty, air-gapped environments, procurement, German government, enterprise AI, Cohere, program management, cloud architecture, on-premises, compliance, regulatory, stakeholder management, PMP, engineering program manager

JOB DESCRIPTION (ARCHIVED)

Archived 2026-05-21 - original posting may be removed after offer closes

Technical Program Manager, AI Delivery for Public Sector & Defence

Company: Cohere

Location: Germany

Employment Type: Full-Time

Cohere seeks an experienced Engineering Program Manager for its customer-facing team, specializing in public sector and defence accounts. This role bridges cutting-edge AI capabilities with government and defence organization needs.

Key Responsibilities:

Customer Program Leadership:

- Manage end-to-end technical delivery for public sector clients from deployment through scaling
- Serve as primary technical contact, building relationships with government CIOs and IT directors
- Transform complex government requirements into actionable engineering plans
- Navigate procurement processes and contractual obligations

Strategic Communication:

- Provide clear updates across engineering and government stakeholders
- Translate AI/ML concepts for non-technical decision-makers
- Present technical roadmaps to senior officials

Complex Program Management:

- Create schedules accounting for government timelines and security reviews
- Manage dependencies across departments and cloud providers
- Address risks including privacy compliance, algorithmic impact assessments, and data sovereignty

Technical Delivery:

- Ensure government-grade security and performance standards
- Coordinate customization, security hardening, and system integration
- Problem-solve in air-gapped or highly regulated environments

Required Qualifications:

- 7+ years as Engineering or Technical Program Manager
- 2+ years in customer-facing technical delivery for enterprise software or AI/ML
- Experience with government, defence, or heavily regulated customers
- Proven track record managing complex, multi-stakeholder programs

Technical Requirements:

- Strong understanding of deployment architectures (cloud, on-premises, hybrid, air-gapped)
- LLM training, fine-tuning, or deployment experience preferred
- Comfort discussing APIs, model inference, and ML operations

Government & Defence Acumen:

- Deep understanding of government technology procurement
- Familiarity with German requirements: data sovereignty, privacy laws, accessibility standards
- Understanding of defence and national security considerations
- Eligible for German government security clearance (Top Secret preferred)

Nice-to-Have:

- Active German security clearance
- German/English bilingual proficiency
- Defence, intelligence, or critical infrastructure experience
- GC Cloud services or Protected B/C environment experience
- Project management certification (PMP, PgMP)

Security Clearance:

The role requires German government security clearance eligibility. Candidates with active Top Secret clearance preferred; those with Secret clearance or eligibility for upgrade also considered. Clearance obtainment may take 12-18 months.

Employee Benefits:

- Inclusive work culture

- Cutting-edge AI research collaboration
- Weekly lunch stipend and in-office meals
- Full health and dental coverage with mental health budget
- 100% parental leave top-up (6 months)
- Personal enrichment benefits
- Remote-flexible work with offices in Toronto, New York, San Francisco, London, Paris
- 6 weeks vacation (30 working days)